

GUIDE 1 OF THE PARENT SERIES

When Your Child Hits or Loses Their Temper

A parent's field guide to understanding anger and aggression in children ages 1–12 — grounded in child-development research, and what actually works in the moment.



BEFORE YOU START

About this guide

Almost every parent has been there: a small hand flies out, or a wave of screaming and tears seems to come from nowhere. It's one of the most common — and most upsetting — moments in raising a child. This guide exists to help you understand what's actually happening in your child's brain in that moment, and give you a calm, repeatable way to handle it.

What's inside

A short tour of the "why" behind anger and hitting, what's typical at each age from toddlerhood through the school years, a simple four-step method you can use in the heat of the moment, ready-to-use scripts, the most common mistakes that quietly make things worse, and how to prevent the storm before it starts.

The approach behind it

This guide draws on positive-discipline research and guidance from the American Academy of Pediatrics and the U.S. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, the emotion-coaching framework developed by psychologist Dr. John Gottman, the "whole-brain" model from Dr. Daniel Siegel and Dr. Tina Payne Bryson, and the Collaborative & Proactive Solutions approach developed by clinical psychologist Dr. Ross Greene. Full sources are listed at the end.

A note before you continue: This guide is educational and is not a substitute for medical or mental-health advice. Every child and family is different. If you're worried about your child's behavior, please speak with your pediatrician or a licensed child psychologist — reaching out is a sign of good parenting, not a failure of it.

CONTENTS

What you'll find inside

01	Understanding the "Why"	04
	The brain science behind anger and hitting, in plain language	
02	What's Normal, By Age	05
	Toddlers, preschoolers, and school-age children each hit different triggers	
03	The C.A.L.M. Path	07
	A simple, repeatable four-step method for the moment it happens	
04	Scripts You Can Use	09
	Exact words by age, for the heat of the moment and the calm after	
05	Common Mistakes	10
	What quietly makes hitting and anger worse — and what to do instead	
06	Preventing the Storm	11
	Daily habits that shrink meltdowns before they start	
07	When to Reach Out	13
	Signs it's worth a conversation with a professional	
08	Quick Reference Sheet	14
	One page to print and keep on the fridge	

SECTION 01

Understanding the "Why"

The single most useful shift you can make as a parent is this: a hit or a meltdown is almost never a choice your child is making to defy you. It's a brain that hasn't finished building the parts it needs to cope.

Two "floors" of the brain

Child psychiatrist Dr. Daniel Siegel describes the brain as having a "downstairs" and an "upstairs." The downstairs brain — wired for survival, instinct, and big emotion — is fully online from birth. The upstairs brain — responsible for reasoning, impulse control, empathy, and problem-solving — is the last part of the brain to finish developing, often not until the mid-twenties.

When a child is overwhelmed, the downstairs brain takes over. Psychologists sometimes call this "flooding" — in that state, language, logic, and self-control genuinely go offline for a few minutes. This is why reasoning, lecturing, or asking "why did you do that?" in the middle of a meltdown almost never works: the part of the brain that could answer you isn't reachable yet.

RESEARCH NOTE

Studies of children's amygdala-prefrontal connectivity (the brain circuit linking emotional reactivity to self-control) show this pathway is still actively maturing throughout early and middle childhood — which is part of why big feelings so easily overwhelm a young child's ability to stay in control of their body.

What this means for you

In the moment itself, your job isn't to teach a lesson — it's to help your child's brain come back "upstairs" so it can think again. The teaching happens afterward, once everyone is calm. Trying to do both at once is why so many in-the-moment conversations go nowhere.

KEEP IN MIND

Hitting and yelling are not signs of a "bad kid" or a parenting failure. They're signs of a young nervous system that needs your help learning to regulate — a skill every child eventually builds, with practice and a calm adult beside them.

SECTION 02

What's Normal, By Age

Anger looks different at 2, at 4, and at 10 — because the brain, language, and life stressors behind it are different too. Here's what to expect at each stage.

TODDLERS • AGES 1–3

At this age, hitting, biting, and throwing are the single most common way big feelings come out — not because your toddler is aggressive by nature, but because their vocabulary and impulse control haven't caught up to the size of their emotions yet. A toddler who wants a toy, feels tired, or gets told "no" often has no other way to express that frustration than with their body.

This behavior typically peaks between about 18 months and 3 years, and gradually eases as language and self-control develop — especially with consistent, calm guidance from the adults around them.

What helps most: very short, simple language ("Hitting hurts. Hands are gentle."), close physical presence, and immediate, calm redirection rather than long explanations, which a toddler's brain can't process mid-meltdown.

PRESCHOOL · AGES 3–6

Language is catching up, but emotional intensity often still outruns it — especially when your child is tired, hungry, or overstimulated. Testing limits ("What happens if I don't listen?") is a normal, healthy part of learning where boundaries are, not defiance for its own sake.

This is also the age where emotion-coaching and simple calm-down tools genuinely start to work, because your child can begin to connect a feeling with a word for it, and a word with a strategy.

What helps most: naming the feeling out loud, offering two acceptable choices instead of an open-ended question, and practicing calm-down tools (breathing, a soft toy, counting) during calm moments so they're familiar when big feelings hit.

SCHOOL AGE · AGES 6–12

Most children at this age can recognize and talk about their anger — usually after the fact, once they've calmed down. Triggers shift toward friendships, fairness, schoolwork, sibling conflict, and difficult transitions (including coming off a screen or a game). A smaller number of children still genuinely struggle to stop a physical reaction in the heat of the moment, and that's worth gentle, ongoing support rather than punishment alone.

What helps most: problem-solving together once things are calm, involving your child in setting family rules and consequences, and helping them notice their own early warning signs ("my chest gets tight," "my hands feel hot") before anger takes over.

WORTH NOTING

Physical aggression that continues or increases at this age — rather than gradually fading, as it does for most children — is one of the signals worth a closer look. See "When to Reach Out" on page 13.

SECTION 03

The C.A.L.M. Path

A simple four-step way to respond in the moment, built on Dr. Siegel's "connect before you correct" principle, Dr. Gottman's emotion-coaching research, and Dr. Greene's collaborative problem-solving approach. It won't feel natural at first — that's normal. Like any skill, it gets easier with repetition.

1

Connect — regulate yourself first

Before you say anything, get physically close and lower yourself to your child's level. Soften your own voice and body — your child's nervous system will often borrow your calm before they can find their own. Say less than you think you need to.

2

Acknowledge — name the feeling

Put words to what you see, without judgment: "You're really angry right now." Naming a feeling isn't the same as agreeing with the behavior — it simply tells your child their emotion makes sense, which is often what allows the intensity to start easing.

3

Limit — kindly and firmly

Separate the feeling from the behavior: "All feelings are okay. Hitting isn't. I won't let you hit me." If needed, calmly and gently block the action or move your child to a safer spot — without punishment in this moment. The limit itself is often what helps a child feel safe enough to settle.

4

Move forward — together

Once everyone is calm — this might be minutes or hours later — briefly revisit what happened: "What were you feeling? What could we try next time?" For younger children this looks more like modeling than discussion; for school-age children, it can be a genuine two-way conversation. This is also the moment to repair — a hug, a kind word — so the relationship resets.

WHY THIS ORDER MATTERS

Connection calms the nervous system so the limit can actually be heard. Setting the limit first — without connecting — often escalates a child who's already flooded. Teaching before anyone is calm rarely sticks at all.

SECTION 04

Scripts You Can Use

You don't need the perfect words — but having a few ready makes the moment easier. Here are exact phrases by age.

AGE	IN THE HEAT OF THE MOMENT	ONCE THINGS ARE CALM
Toddler 1–3	"Hitting hurts. Hands are gentle." "I won't let you hit. I'm holding your hands."	"That was hard. You wanted the toy." <i>(Keep it brief — show, more than explain.)</i>
Preschool 3–6	"You're so angry right now. I'm right here." "I won't let you hit your brother. Show me angry hands instead — like this."	"What happened? What can we do differently next time?" "Let's practice what 'angry hands' can do instead."
School age 6–12	"I can see you're furious. Take the space you need — I'm nearby when you're ready." "Hitting isn't okay, no matter how angry you are."	"Walk me through what happened. What was going on for you?" "What's one thing you could do differently, and one thing I can do to help?"

TIP

Your tone matters more than your exact words. Said with a calm, warm voice, even an imperfect script works better than a perfect one delivered in frustration.

SECTION 05

Common Mistakes

These reactions are completely understandable in the heat of the moment — every parent has reached for one of them. But research consistently shows they tend to make future hitting and anger more likely, not less.

Tends to backfire

- Hitting or spanking back ("teaching" not to hit, by hitting)
- Shouting "STOP HITTING RIGHT NOW"
- Labeling: "you're a bad boy," "you always do this"
- Lecturing or reasoning mid-meltdown
- Completely ignoring a genuine emotional flood
- Comparing to a sibling or another child
- Empty threats you won't follow through on

Works better

- Staying calm yourself, or visibly trying to
- Getting down to your child's eye level
- Naming the feeling before addressing the behavior
- Holding the limit firmly, without punishment in the moment
- Repairing the relationship once things are calm
- Noticing and praising calm moments, not just meltdowns
- Following through on limits you've actually set

RESEARCH NOTE

The American Academy of Pediatrics' policy on effective discipline recommends against spanking and harsh verbal punishment, citing evidence that these approaches are linked to increased aggression over time rather than reduced it — and recommends positive, consistent, non-physical discipline instead.

SECTION 06

Preventing the Storm

You can't prevent every meltdown — and you shouldn't try to. But a handful of daily habits meaningfully reduce how often and how intensely they happen.

Fill the cup first

Ten to fifteen minutes of undivided, phone-away attention a day — following your child's lead in play — does more to prevent big blow-ups than almost anything you can do in the moment itself. Children who feel consistently connected have less need to escalate to be noticed.

Check the basics before the behavior

Hunger, tiredness, and overstimulation are behind a huge share of "out of nowhere" meltdowns. Before addressing behavior, it's worth quickly asking: has my child eaten recently? Slept enough? Been going nonstop with no downtime? Often, the fastest fix is a snack, rest, or five quiet minutes — not a conversation.

Build the vocabulary before you need it

Talk about feelings during calm moments — in books, shows, or everyday life ("that character looks really frustrated, doesn't he?"). A child who has practiced the words "angry," "frustrated," and "disappointed" in low-stakes moments is far more likely to reach for words instead of hands under real pressure.

Give warnings before transitions

Sudden changes are hard for any child. A "five more minutes" warning, a visual timer, or a simple routine for switching activities gives your child's brain time to prepare, rather than being caught off guard.

Build a calm-down spot — together

Set up a cozy corner with a soft toy, cushions, or a breathing visual, and introduce it as a place to feel better, not a punishment. Practice using it together on ordinary days, so it's familiar by the time it's actually needed.

SCREENS & BIG FEELINGS — A QUICK NOTE

Research links fast-paced or overstimulating screen content with a lower threshold for meltdowns — especially right when the screen turns off. A visual countdown before ending screen time, a calm transition ritual, and avoiding high-energy content right before bed or during an already-hard moment all help. We go much deeper on this in our next guide in this series, *Screens & Big Feelings*.

Model it out loud

Let your child see you managing your own frustration: "I'm feeling really frustrated right now. I'm going to take three deep breaths." Children learn regulation far more from watching it than from being told about it.

SECTION 07

When to Reach Out

Anger and occasional hitting are a normal, expected part of childhood — this guide exists because of that. But a few patterns are worth a conversation with your pediatrician or a licensed child psychologist:

- Physical aggression is becoming more frequent or more intense past age 5–6, rather than gradually easing
- Your child hurts other children, animals, or themselves intentionally, with little sign of remorse afterward
- Anger is significantly affecting friendships, school, or day-to-day family life
- It's appearing alongside other changes — sleep problems, developmental regression, extreme fear, or persistent sadness
- You feel genuinely unsafe, exhausted, or unable to cope on your own

PLEASE REMEMBER

Reaching out for support is not a sign that you've failed as a parent — it's one of the most effective things you can do for your child. A pediatrician, child psychologist, or family therapist can help identify what's underneath the behavior and build a plan suited to your specific child.

SECTION 08 • PRINT & KEEP

Quick Reference

Keep this page on the fridge for the next hard moment.

The C.A.L.M. Path

1. **Connect** — get close, get calm
2. **Acknowledge** — name the feeling
3. **Limit** — kindly and firmly
4. **Move forward** — repair, then problem-solve

Say this

"You're really angry right now."
"All feelings are okay. Hitting isn't."
"I won't let you hit — I'm right here."

Skip this

Hitting back · Shouting "stop hitting" · Labeling ("bad boy/girl") · Lecturing mid-meltdown · Empty threats

Check first

Hungry? Tired? Overstimulated? Just came off a screen? Fix the basics before addressing the behavior.

Reach out if...

Hitting is increasing past age 5–6 · hurts others/animals with little remorse · affecting friendships or school · paired with sleep or mood changes → talk to your pediatrician or a child psychologist.

SOURCES & FURTHER READING

Where this guide comes from

American Academy of Pediatrics. "Effective Discipline to Raise Healthy Children," Pediatrics, and AAP policy on corporal punishment.

U.S. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention. "Essentials for Parenting Toddlers and Preschoolers."

Gottman, J. & DeClaire, J. Raising an Emotionally Intelligent Child — the Emotion Coaching framework, The Gottman Institute.

Siegel, D. & Bryson, T.P. The Whole-Brain Child — "upstairs/downstairs brain" model.

Greene, R.W. The Explosive Child — Collaborative & Proactive Solutions (CPS).

Cleveland Clinic Health Essentials. "Toddler Hitting? Toddler Aggression and When to Worry."

American Psychological Association. Research coverage on screen time and children's emotional regulation.

This guide is part of the Peep & Beyond Parent Series, created to give parents clear, research-informed support for the everyday moments of raising kids — on and off the screen. It is educational in nature and does not replace individualized medical or mental-health care.

With you, one hard moment at a time.

— Peep & Beyond